



Journal of Product & Brand Management

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Article information:

To cite this document:

Philippa Hankinson Wendy Lomax Chris Hand, (2007), "The time factor in re-branding organizations: its effects on staff knowledge, attitudes and behaviour in UK charities", Journal of Product & Brand Management, Vol. 16 Iss 4 pp. 236 - 246

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The time factor in re-branding organizations: its effects on staff knowledge, attitudes and behaviour in UK charities

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Abstract

Purpose – As staff are vital to successful re-branding, particularly in the charity sector where restricted budgets limit reliance on external marketing, it is important to understand the impact of re-branding on staff. This study aims to examine the effect of time on staff knowledge, attitudes and behaviour and, in addition, the interaction of time with seniority, tenure and level of support for re-branding.

Design/methodology/approach – The paper first explores the literature from both the for-profit and non-profit sectors. A quantitative study was undertaken in nine leading, UK charities that had re-branded two, three and four years ago; $n = 345$. The data were analysed using one-way and two-way ANOVAs.

Findings – A negative relationship was found between time since re-branding and the three constructs of knowledge, attitudes and behaviour. But this consistency was not mirrored by a consistency in the impact of interaction effects.

Practical implications – Re-branding is not a one-off event. To sustain its benefits, organizations need to re-visit its outcomes on a regular basis to ensure staff retain new knowledge, remain positively motivated and maintain their recently adapted behaviours over time.

Originality/value – Thought to be the first empirical paper to explore the effects of re-branding over time. Furthermore, the findings contradict those from the extant literature that claim that organizational change requires a “settling in” period. By contrast these findings suggest that the positive effects of re-branding are best felt in the immediate wake of re-branding and thereafter fade over time.

Keywords Brands, Time-based management, Charities, United Kingdom

Paper type Research paper

An executive summary for managers and executive readers can be found at the end of this article

Introduction

Re-branding is a consequence of time. To remain relevant and desirable, it is necessary to re-visit the organizational proposition and re-assess its strategic value to stakeholders. Hence, re-branding signals change, a new beginning and hopefully a better one (Stuart and Muzellec, 2004).

While re-branding is often managed by external branding consultants, the implementation is the responsibility of the staff within the organizations. Their role is pivotal to the success of re-branding (Free, 1999; Ind and Bell, 2000; Webster, 2002) and it is they who ultimately own its consequences. Hence staff are key stakeholders in its effectiveness.

Hankinson and Lomax (2006) use three dimensions to measure the effectiveness of re-branding; the acquisition of new knowledge, (new straplines, messages and values), more favourable attitudes (feeling involved or valued by the

organization) and more positive behaviours (working more co-operatively with colleagues). Some may argue that staff require time to internalise fully the consequences of re-branding; that there is a “settling in” period as staff adapt to a new or re-focused brand reality (Ind, 1997, 2004). This suggests that staff in organizations with longer distance from re-branding will demonstrate higher levels of knowledge, more favourable attitudes and more positive behaviours than those in organizations that have re-branded more recently.

Alternatively, it has been argued that staff are more likely to respond positively to internal change in the immediate wake of the re-branding process (Kaikati and Kaikati, 2003). This opposing hypothesis suggests that time distance will show employees with lower levels of knowledge, less favourable attitudes and more negative behaviours.

Through quantitative research, this study explores the issue of time in nine leading, UK charities. First, it examines the re-branding literature in both the for-profit and charity sectors and secondly it explores the effects of time since re-branding on staff knowledge, attitudes and behaviours. In particular, the study examines the interaction of time with seniority, tenure and level of support for the re-branding process.

Literature review

Re-branding organizations

Re-branding is a strategy designed to signal change. Its most obvious signals surround its visual identity, its name, logo, strapline and colours either singly or plurally. But

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Journal of Product & Brand Management
16/4 (2007) 236–246
© Emerald Group Publishing Limited [ISSN 1061-0421]
[DOI 10.1108/10610420710763921]

underlying these overt signs of change is a more fundamental reason. The significant costs associated with identity make-overs involve the re-evaluation of the organization's proposition (Lomax and Mador, 2006; Boyle, 2002; Kaikati and Kaikati, 2003). Weick (1995, p. 16) describes this process as "an expression in organizational sense making".

Initially, such fundamental change contradicts traditional marketing theory with its emphasis on consistency in building strong and successful brands (Hankinson and Hankinson, 1999; Aaker and Joachimsthaler, 2000; De Chernatony, 2001). However long term brand management predicates an ongoing review of the original proposition to ensure its continued relevance (Feder, 1998), contemporaneity (Kaikati and Kaikati, 2003) and uniqueness in the face of environmental change (Knox and Macklan, 1998). Hence re-branding organizations are those that re-visit their organizational propositions and re-assess their strategic value to target markets.

Drivers for re-branding may be prompted by a fall in revenue caused by a decline in voluntary donations in the charity sector. It may be prompted by mergers, for example, Guinness and Grand Metropolitan which formed Diageo in 2000 or Imperial Cancer Research Fund and Cancer Research Campaign forming Cancer Research UK in 2003; or de-mergers as when Andersen Consulting distanced itself from Arthur Andersen Worldwide and became Accenture in 2001. Another trigger may be a need to adapt to modern values as when the Spastics Society became Scope to avoid the stigmatising image of spasticity (Lomax and Mador, 2006); or to provide a single global presence as when HSBC subsumed eight local brands, world-wide, under a single brand name (Lomax and Mador, 2006). Alternatively, re-branding may result from the appointment of a new chief executive, possibly brought into address organizational problems. In each of these circumstances, a "paint job" to the visual identity of the organization may be found wanting (Coles, 2003), as British Airways found to their cost when they rolled out their new "tailfin" campaign. While the campaign was designed to represent "visual celebrations of the world's diversity" (Hatch and Schultz, 2003, p. 1053), British Airways failed to follow through with changes to the organization's proposition. Only if the visual identity is accompanied by real change within organizations will the re-brand have any meaning to stakeholders.

Staff roles in re-branding

People are a significant part of the services mix, (Booms and Bitner, 1981). It is surprising, therefore, that the concept and practice of internal branding, which recognises the fundamental importance of people in delivering the brand experience, has received less attention than external branding. Nevertheless, in the last decade, marketers have laid more emphasis on the contribution of staff to brand success (De Chernatony and Segal-Horn, 2001; Bergstrom *et al.*, 2002; Ahmed and Rafiq, 2003; Lomax and Mador, 2006). There is a recognition that staff are key to building relationships with stakeholders, including brand users (Hatch and Schultz, 2001) and are an integral part of the brand itself (Thomson and Hecker, 2000; Ind and Bell, 2000). As a result, Ahmed and Rafiq (2003) propose that relationship marketing provides a more plausible theoretical approach to internal marketing than the traditional transactional approach that has previously underpinned the notion of "employees as customers" (Berry, 1981, p. 26).

The literature on the contribution of staff to re-branding is limited despite its importance. Thomson *et al.* (1999) emphasise the importance of staff understanding the values the organization represents. They argue that staff need to internalise these values before they deliver them to stakeholders. Alternatively, an organization may recruit staff on the basis that their values are already aligned to those of the organisation (Hankinson, 2000, 2004), a process known as value-based interviewing and considered particularly appropriate to the charity sector (Stainton-Williamson, 2005; Girod, 2005). Ahmed and Rafiq (2003) emphasise the significance of staff commitment to organizations. They report that commitment and involvement when coupled with a clear sense of purpose are a "prerequisite for the much needed coherence and focus that are ultimately required to produce successful outcomes" (Ahmed and Rafiq, 2003, p.1179). A third aspect of how staff contribute to the branding of an organization lies in behaviour. Here studies by Thomson and Hecker (2000), Ahmed and Rafiq (2002, 2003) and Aurand *et al.* (2005) from the for-profit sector and Ind and Bell (2000) and Hankinson (2004) from the charity sector emphasise the importance of "living the brand", i.e. behaving in ways that reflect the values of the organization. It is the acid test of how sincerely staff internalise the organizational proposition (Hankinson, 2004).

It follows, therefore, that any change to the corporate or charity brand will, of necessity, require the full participation and support of staff (Boyle, 2002; Kaikati and Kaikati, 2003; Coles, 2003).

The time factor in re-branding

Some of the marketing literature on re-branding notes that organizations need time to change (Ind, 1997; Hankinson and Hankinson, 1999). Staff need to internalise new brand values, for example, to commit to those values and to behave differently (Kaikati, 2003; Coles, 2003; Hankinson, 2004). This view is also supported by human resource theorists who argue that the fear of change can slow its adoption and in some cases lead to counter-implementation (Keen, 1981; Recardo, 1991; Boddy, 2002). Kotter and Schlesinger (1979) make a similar point when they note that staff may not understand the advantages of change and perceive the cost to be greater than the benefit. Change management theorists also argue that staff need time to adapt to change (Mintzberg, 1994; Stacey, 1994; Clarry, 1999). These writers note that introducing change to organizations is an emergent or adaptive process during which staff learn new ways of thinking and doing.

The literature describes ways of speeding up the adaptive process. Visionary leadership is considered a vital ingredient here. Ind and Bell (2000), Gratton (2004) and Lomax and Mador (2006) emphasise the importance of senior management engaging staff in the change process, both in its planning and its implementation. Boddy (2002, p. 332) observes that "if people can say 'I helped to build this', they are more willing to live and work with it".

Asif and Sargeant (2000) and De Chernatony and Segal-Horn (2001) note that good communication can also help speed up the embedding process. The more efficient the channel of communication, the faster re-branding messages reach stakeholders (Hankinson and Lomax, 2006). Furthermore, marketing case studies report on the importance of effective communication to communicate

change (Hankinson and Hankinson, 1998; Kaikati and Kaikati, 2003; Coles, 2003). Bergstrom *et al.* (2002) identify three essential elements for effective communication:

- 1 high status of the leader;
- 2 high frequency messages; and
- 3 the use of multiple channels of communication.

The evidence so far seems to suggest that re-branding requires time to embed itself within organizations and that its effects on staff will be more apparent, longer-term.

However, from the organizational behaviour literature, Gagliardi (1986) describes a different phenomenon which may shed light on how quickly and how permanently change may take place in organizations. He identifies three types of change. The first type he calls apparent change. Here the organizational identity changes in terms of its artifacts, for example its name, logo and symbols but there will be no significant change to the organization's deeper values, its vision and mission. Hence the original organizational proposition remains intact. The second type of change he calls revolutionary change which typically exists in merger scenarios. Here, there may be root and branch change to both the organizational identity and the proposition as new logos and symbols and new values are imposed at the expense of the original. The third type of change, Gagliardi (1986), terms cultural incrementalism that is the only type of change that reaches a deeper level by promoting the co-existence of both old and new values. Gagliardi (1986) argues therefore, that whereas the second (revolutionary) and third (cultural incrementalism) types of change may result in longer lasting change, the first type of change (apparent) may be shorter lived.

Case studies in the re-branding literature in both the for-profit and charity sectors also demonstrate shorter term effects as staff become energised by the huge orchestration that often accompanies a re-branding roll-out and quickly embrace concomitant change – see Smirnoff (Hankinson and Hankinson, 1998); Voluntary Services Overseas (Ind and Bell, 2000); Accenture (Kaikati and Kaikati, 2003). One explanation may lie in the Hawthorne effect in which any change to the working environment may influence performance, simply because staff feel “more special” as the organization takes notice of them (Boddy, 2002).

From the advertising literature, there is further evidence to suggest short-term change. Jefkin and Yadin (2000) and Fill (2002) for example note that the impact of advertising deteriorates or decays once the advertising has ended i.e. that recognition and recall of advertising is short-lived, that memory fades. Hence the need for sustained advertising or repeated advertising bursts. Bogart (1995) and White and Dawson (2003) also support the need for repetition, claiming that the longer the interval between repetitions, the greater the opportunity for interference from competing messages. Hence there can be “no recency without frequency” (White and Dawson, 2003, p. 42).

Re-branding is a comparatively new area of study. It is also an expensive management initiative that may prompt criticism, particularly in the context of charities where some might see it as being funded at the expense of their beneficiaries. This study investigates a number of leading UK charities and explores the effect of time since re-branding on staff knowledge, attitudes and behaviour as well as its interactive effects.

Research objectives

This study extends the approach of Hankinson and Lomax (2006) in which staff responses to re-branding were measured according to three consistently well documented dimensions from the branding literature: knowledge, attitudes and behaviour. Knowledge, for instance, relates to an understanding of the organization's proposition, its values and vision, its logo and slogan. A good understanding of what the organization does and how it does it, is thought fundamental to staff commitment to the organization (Hankinson, 2004; Thomson *et al.*, 1999; Free, 1999). Attitudes are generally perceived as the emotional link with knowledge (Thomson *et al.*, 1999; Ambler and Barrow, 1996) which some also perceive as key to organizational success (Burman and Zeplin, 2005; Thomson, 1998). Attitudes may help determine the extent to which knowledge is acted on in the interests of the organization (Burman and Zeplin, 2005). Finally, brand behaviour, what Burman and Zeplin (2005) identify as “brand citizenship” in which staff “live the brand” (Ind, 2004; Hankinson, 2004), for instance, adopting considerate and co-operative behaviours to colleagues or engaging with staff training. Behaviour is the acid test of brand reality, where knowledge of and attitudes towards the organisation result in positive brand behaviours (Hankinson, 2004; Bergstrom *et al.*, 2002).

This study explores the effect of time since re-branding on these three conceptual foci. It also explores the interactive effects time since re-branding with seniority within the charity, length of service and the extent to which re-branding is supported.

Knowledge

- H1. The acquisition of new knowledge is less likely in organizations that have re-branded for longer.
- H1a. The effect of time since re-branding on knowledge is influenced by seniority within the charity.
- H1b. The effect of time since re-branding on knowledge is influenced by years spent with the charity (tenure).
- H1c. The effect of time since re-branding on knowledge is influenced by support for rebranding.

Attitudes

- H2. Attitudinal change is less likely in organisations that have re-branded for longer.
- H2a. The effect of time since re-branding on attitudes is influenced by seniority within the charity.
- H2b. The effect of time since re-branding on attitudes is influenced by tenure within the charity.
- H2c. The effect of time since re-branding on attitudes is influenced by support for re-branding.

Behaviour

- H3. Behavioural change is less likely in organisations that have re-branded for longer.
- H3a. The effect of time since re-branding on behaviour is influenced by seniority.
- H3b. The effect of time since re-branding on behaviour is influenced by tenure within the charity.
- H3c. The effect of time since re-branding on behaviour is influenced by support for re-branding.

Methodology

Sample

The research was undertaken among leading UK charities (Charity Trends, 2003) as larger charities were more likely to have the resources to re-brand. Those charities that had re-branded in the last four years were identified through a short telephone interview with the Top 100 charities, as defined by voluntary income. From a total of 70 responding charities, 38 were found to have re-branded in the last four years. From this a convenience sample of ten leading charities was drawn. Two charities had re-branded four years ago, three charities had re-branded three years ago and four charities had re-branded two years ago and one charity had re-branded in the last year.

Questionnaire design

A total of 25 item statements were developed around the three conceptual foci of knowledge, attitudes and behaviour. A six-point agreement scale accompanied each item statement from “strongly agree”(6) to “strongly disagree”(1) which allowed a wide spread of responses. There was no neutral mid-point to avoid participant passivity. Six item statements were negatively worded to reduce survey participants adopting directional bias in their responses. In addition, there were two demographic questions relating to level of seniority and length of service and four items (with six-point agreement scales as above) relating to level of support for re-branding (see Appendix 1). The item statements may be assumed to have face validity, which though subjective in nature, nevertheless involves a common-sense interpretation of the three foci of interest.

Pre-testing the questionnaire

The 31-item questionnaire was mailed to a senior contact in one of the ten charities in the research sample. The manager then distributed the survey, through the internal mail, to 50 members of staff. A total of 15 questionnaires were returned of which one was partially completed, yielding a usable pre-test sample of 14 (28 per cent). Reliability analyses and item-total statistics revealed no significant problems. This pre-testing stage identified the absence of a “summary” question for the “support” dimension. This issue was remedied by the generation of an additional item statement for the main survey.

Main survey

A total of 1,425 questionnaires were sent to members of staff at the ten identified charities. (In the case of the pre-test charity, different members of staff were approached for the main survey). The method of distribution of questionnaires within charities varied with the wishes of the senior contacts. Some took responsibility for internal distribution of questionnaires via e-mail or hard copy while others provided name/address labels. In all cases, the senior contact was briefed to send questionnaires to a cross section of staff including senior management, middle/lower management and clerical/administrative staff, whose tenure preceded re-branding. Every questionnaire was accompanied with a reply paid envelope to ensure confidentiality of response.

A combination of techniques designed to raise response levels of postal questionnaires (Dillman, 1978; Gendall *et al.*, 1995, 1998; Turley, 1999) resulted in a response rate of 33 per cent ($n = 465$).

Ethical considerations

The principle of informed consent was paramount. Each questionnaire was accompanied with a covering letter stating the purpose of the research and the impartiality and independence of the researchers. In accordance with the ethics of both universities, the principles of the British Sociological Association and the Market Research Society, the data were held in strictest confidence and the analysis ensured anonymity of research subjects.

Data analysis

We defined levels of seniority (senior management, middle/lower management, clerical/administrative), length of service (0–2 years, 3–6 years, 7+ years) and support for rebranding (high, medium and low).

The original sample contained responses from ten different charities. One charity in our sample had re-branded one year before the survey. Preliminary analysis suggested that the responses from this charity followed a very different pattern from the remainder of the data, reporting significantly lower scores than others on all of our measures. Consequently this charity was omitted from the analysis. Descriptive statistics for the data set appear in Table I ($n = 345$).

Cronbach's alpha was calculated for our four constructs, each showed high levels of consistency between items and each of the three conceptual foci (knowledge 0.860, attitudes 0.906 and behaviour 0.768) as well as the five support questions (0.828), an indication of the reliability of the item statements to produce consistent results with repeated measures. As a result no question was excluded from the main analysis.

Independent variables were created by aggregating item scores from questions around each of the conceptual foci to form a single composite score for knowledge, attitudes and behaviour. The five “support” questions were re-scaled into “high”, “medium” and “low” support categories in which the distribution was allowed “to define what is high and low as opposed to the researcher's arbitrary notions” (de Vaus, 1996, p. 273) – see Appendices 1–4 for item questions making up composites.

Table I Frequencies and percentages of independent variables

	Frequency	Per cent
<i>Job position</i>		
Senior management	71	21.2
Middle/lower management	176	52.5
Administrative/clerical	88	26.3
Total	335	100.0
<i>Years working in charity</i>		
0–2 years	49	14.2
3–6 years	117	33.9
7+ years	179	51.9
Total	345	100.0
<i>Level of support</i>		
Low	102	29.7
Medium	109	31.7
High	133	38.6
Total	344	100.0

Survey results

Our first three hypotheses focus on whether knowledge, attitude and behaviour scores differ across time since re-branding:

- H1. The acquisition of new knowledge is less likely in organizations that have re-branded for longer.
- H2. Attitudinal change is less likely in organizations that have re-branded for longer.
- H3. Behavioural change is less likely in organizations which have re-branded for longer.

These hypotheses are tested using one-way ANOVA; the results appear in Table II.

There are significant differences in knowledge, attitude and behaviour scores across time since rebranding occurred ($p < 0.00$). Although in each case the differences are significant, the size of the effect as shown by the η^2 is, at best, moderate (Cohen, 1988, suggests a value of $\eta^2 = 0.01$ indicates a small effect, $0.06 =$ moderate effect and $0.14 =$ a large effect). In support of our expectations, *Post hoc* analyses (using the Scheffe test) revealed a negative relationship between time since re-branding and our three constructs, knowledge, attitudes and behaviour: charities that had re-branded within two years of the survey had significantly higher scores on our constructs than those that had re-branded four years before the survey.

The remaining hypotheses were tested using two-way ANOVA, to allow us to test for interaction effects between time since re-branding and seniority, tenure and support.

H1a. The effect of time since rebranding on knowledge is influenced by seniority within the charity.

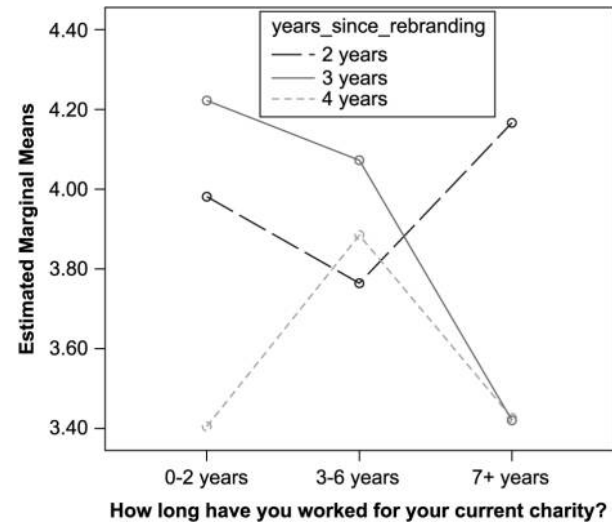
This hypothesis is not supported. Small, but statistically significant main effects were found for seniority ($F(2, 321)=5.46$, $p = 0.005$, $\eta^2 = 0.03$) and time since rebranding ($F(2, 321)=7.38$, $p = 0.001$, $\eta^2 = 0.04$). The mean knowledge score for senior managers and middle/lower managers was significantly higher than the mean for administrative/clerical staff. However, the interaction effect did not reach statistical significance ($F(4, 321)=0.91$, $p = 0.46$).

H1b. The effect of time since rebranding on knowledge is influenced by years spent with the charity (tenure).

This hypothesis was supported. A small, but statistically significant main effect for time since re-branding was found ($F(2,330)=3.66$, $p = 0.027$, $\eta^2 = 0.027$), but time with the charity was not significant ($F(2,330)=1.48$, $p = 0.23$). However, the interaction between time since rebranding and time with the charity was significant ($F(4, 330)=3.99$, $p = 0.01$, $\eta^2 = 0.04$), although again the effect size was small.

As Figure 1 shows in charities that re-branded four years ago, those who have worked for the charity for 3-6 years (those who had just joined the charity when the re-branding took place) have a higher mean knowledge score than those

Figure 1 Interaction between years since re-branding and tenure on mean knowledge



who had worked for the charity for 0-2 years and those who had worked at the charity for longer. The opposite pattern can be seen in charities that re-branded two years ago.

H1c. The effect of time since rebranding on knowledge is influenced by support for re-branding.

This hypothesis is not supported. Significant direct effects are found for support ($F(2, 332)=32.29$, $p = 0.00$, $\eta^2 = 0.16$) and years since rebranding ($F(2,332)=4.77$, $p = 0.01$, $\eta^2 = 0.03$), with support having a larger effect on knowledge than time since re-branding. However, the interaction term is not significant ($F(4, 332)=0.836$, $p = 0.50$).

H2a. The effect of time since re-branding on attitudes is influenced by seniority within the charity.

This hypothesis is supported. Both seniority ($F(2,325)=3.98$, $p = 0.02$, $\eta^2 = 0.02$) and time since rebranding ($F(2,325)=17.00$, $p = 0.00$, $\eta^2 = 0.1$) are statistically significant, as is the interaction term ($F(4, 325)=4.07$, $p = 0.03$, $\eta^2 = 0.05$). Hence the effect of seniority on the mean attitude score does depend on time since re-branding, although again, the effect sizes are small.

As Figure 2 shows, there is a similar distribution of mean scores across seniority levels in charities that re-branded three and four years ago. In charities that re-branded two years ago, respondents at all levels had higher mean attitude scores than those in charities which had re-branded longer ago. The difference is more pronounced among senior managers. However, this change in attitudes would appear to be short-lived.

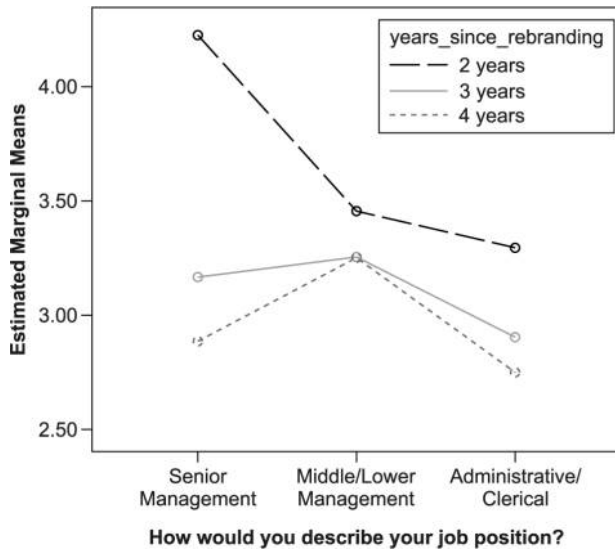
H2b. The effect of time since re-branding on attitude is influenced by tenure within the charity.

This hypothesis is supported. While years since re-branding has a small, but significant direct effect on attitude ($F(2, 334)=7.53$, $p = 0.00$, $\eta^2 = 0.04$), time with the charity does not ($F(2, 334)=1.43$, $p = 0.14$). Rather, time with the charity and time since re-branding have a statistically significant joint effect; the interaction term is statistically significant ($F(4, 334)=2.88$, $p = 0.02$, $\eta^2 = 0.03$).

Table II One-way ANOVA results

Construct	F	df	p-value	Effect size (η^2)
Knowledge	6.67	2, 341	0.00	0.04
Attitude	10.576	2, 345	0.00	0.06
Behaviour	7.55	2, 342	0.00	0.04

Figure 2 Interaction of time since re-branding and seniority on mean attitude



As Figure 3 shows, those who have worked for a charity which re-branded two years ago for seven or more years show a higher mean attitude score. Conversely, those who have worked for a charity which re-branded four years ago for up to two years have a lower mean attitude score. This would seem to suggest that rebranding can only influence the attitudes of those who worked for the charity while it was re-branded. *H2c*. The effect of time since rebranding on attitude is influenced by support for re-branding.

This hypothesis is supported. Both time since re-branding and support for re-branding have a significant direct effect on attitudes ($F(2, 335)=8.66, p=0.00, \eta^2=0.05$ and $F(2, 335)=53.63, p=0.00, \eta^2=0.24$ respectively). The interaction term is also significant ($F(4, 335)=3.55, p=0.00, \eta^2=0.04$).

As Figure 4 shows, in general, the higher the support for re-branding, the higher the mean attitude score, as might be

Figure 3 Interaction of time since re-branding and tenure on attitude

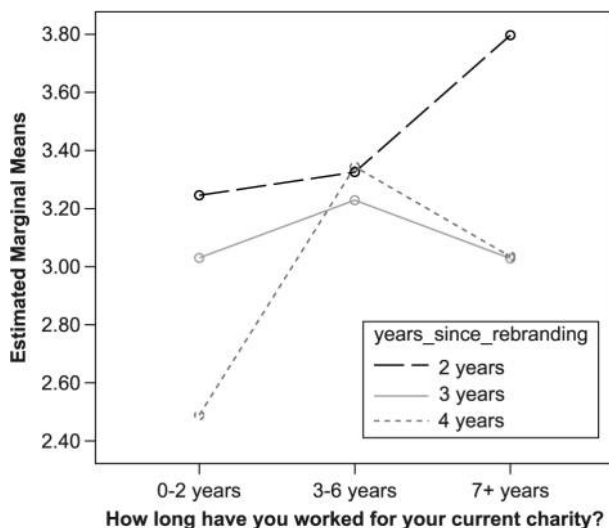
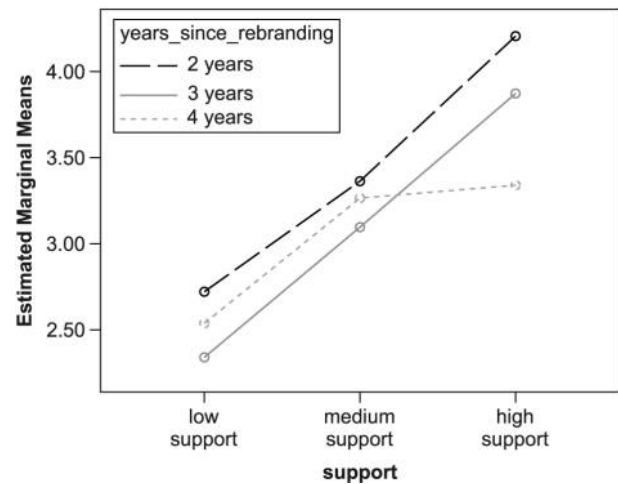


Figure 4 Interaction of time since re-branding and support for re-branding on attitudes



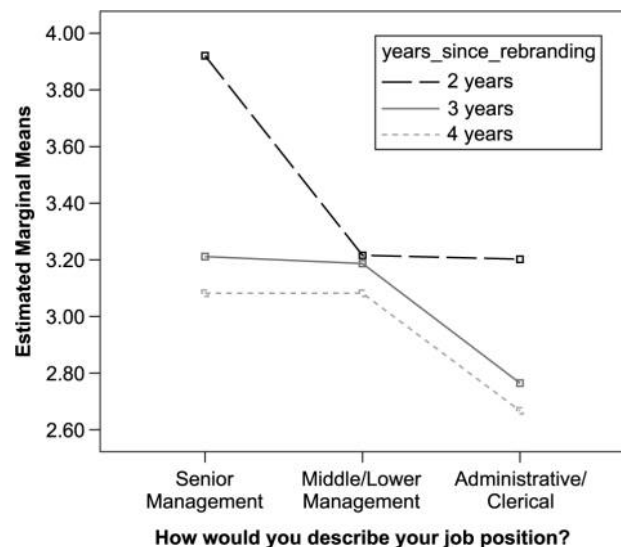
expected. However, in charities that have re-branded four years ago, the mean attitude score of those who strongly support re-branding has fallen to a similar level as medium supporters of re-branding.

H3a. The effect of time since re-branding on behaviour is influenced by seniority.

This hypothesis is supported. Both seniority ($F(2,322)=5.81, p=0.00, \eta^2=0.04$) and time since re-branding ($F(2,322)=11.78, p=0.00, \eta^2=0.07$) are significant. The interaction term between these two variables is also significant ($F(4,322)=2.50, p=0.04, \eta^2=0.03$).

As Figure 5 shows, senior managers and clerical/administrative staff in charities which re-branded two years ago record higher behaviour scores than those in charities which re-branded longer ago. This would seem to suggest that the effect of re-branding on behaviour is short-lived and has little effect on middle/lower managers.

Figure 5 Interaction of time since re-branding and seniority on behaviour



H3b. The effect of time since re-branding on behaviour is influenced by tenure with the charity.

This hypothesis is not supported. Neither tenure ($F(2,331)=0.94$, $p=0.39$) nor the interaction of tenure and time since re-branding ($F(4,331)=1.46$, $p=0.215$) are significant. Years since re-branding does have a small but significant effect on mean behaviour ($F(2,331)=4.63$, $p=0.01$, $\eta^2=0.03$).

H3c. The effect of time since re-branding on behaviour is influenced by support for re-branding.

This hypothesis is not supported. Although support for re-branding has a clear effect on behaviour ($F(2,332)=32.05$, $p=0.00$, $\eta^2=0.16$) and years since re-branding has a lesser effect ($F(2,332)=4.80$, $p=0.01$, $\eta^2=0.03$), the interaction term between it and years since re-branding is not significant ($F(2,332)=4.80$, $p=0.11$).

Discussion and conclusions

Our results show a negative relationship between time since re-branding and the three constructs of knowledge, attitude and behaviour. But this consistency shown between these foci, is not mirrored by a consistency in the impact of interaction effects.

Knowledge

Respondents from charities who had rebranded within two years of our survey felt that they knew more about the charity as a result of the process. They claimed to be more aware of the charity's vision, values and beneficiaries than those who had rebranded earlier (i.e. four years before). This acquisition of knowledge declines as time since the rebranding increases.

Seniority does not appear to have an effect. This may be because more senior managers feel that they already have a high level of knowledge of the charity's values and do not need the prompt that the re-branding process offers. The main divide is between managers (senior/middle/lower) and administrative/clerical staff, but even this is not significant.

Tenure does appear to have an impact. The interaction effect between time and tenure varies depending on the length of time since re-branding. For charities which have recently re-branded, long-time employees feel they gained the most knowledge. Of those charities that have re-branded in the mid-term, most recent recruits feel they have benefited most in knowledge terms. Longer term re-branding shows a similar bi-polar pattern with mid tenure employees claiming to have gained most knowledge from the process. It is possible that our grouping of tenure into three discrete clusters masks the fact that what is important is how long the employee was in the organization before it re-branded and linked to this whether their recruitment was contemporaneous with the re-branding process. Another factor to be considered is the magnitude of the re-branding. We have used rebranding as a discrete variable whereas the reality may be that it would be better viewed as a continuous one. A change of colour on the logo should be viewed as a different level of shift compared to a change in organizational values.

Support for re-branding does have a significant effect on claimed acquisition of knowledge but this is regardless of time. Level of support of the staff does have an effect but its effect is not increased or diminished by the passing of time since the re-branding process. Organizations should therefore

see investment in gaining staff buy-in to be a critical success factor that will not depreciate over time.

Attitude

The time effect was most marked on attitude of our three constructs. Respondents felt more positive about working for the charity the closer they were to the re-branding process. Their attitudes, while still remaining positive, diminished over time as the re-branding faded in the memory.

Seniority does have an effect here with managers in general feeling more motivated about the charity after re-branding. This could be because managers feel more involved in the decision-making process associated with re-branding; administrative and clerical staff by comparison may feel that the process has been imposed on them. All managers, whether they be senior, middle or lower, have a consistently more positive attitude than more junior staff.

Tenure also has a significant interaction effect. It is likely that employees who have remained with the charity for longer hold more positive attitudes or they would have chosen to leave. Employees who were not working for the charity at the point of re-branding are unsurprisingly less affected by the process.

The level of support for re-branding also makes a difference. Employees who claim a higher level of support show consistently more positive attitudes. This is true regardless of the time since re-branding, although more pronounced in the organisations which had re-branded more recently.

Behaviour

As with the other two constructs, behavioural changes are more pronounced closest to the point of re-branding. This makes intuitive sense as employees adapt their behaviour as a reaction to the stimulus.

Seniority also has an effect here with managers, at all levels noting behavioural changes. Administrative and clerical staff claim less effect and even this declines over time. Neither tenure nor level of support has an effect on behavioural change. This is surprising, given the results on attitude. It may reflect the more informal way that charities approach re-branding, perhaps spending less money and time on re-branding seminars and re-training exercises.

Management implications

- 1 Re-branding is not a one-off event. To sustain its benefits, charities need to re-visit its outcomes, on a regular basis, to ensure staff retain their new knowledge, remain positively motivated and maintain their recently adapted behaviours over time. Lunchtime seminars, away days and regular training activities should be used to sustain change brought about by re-branding.
- 2 Charities employing outside agencies should ensure that a senior member of staff is in place to take responsibility and ensure the continuation of re-branding outcomes once the brand agency withdraws.
- 3 Administrative and clerical staff need to be more involved with the re-branding process. They also need to be targeted with communications that increase their brand knowledge to levels commensurate with those of managerial staff to counter-act the fading of knowledge over time.

- 4 Longer serving staff in charities that have re-branded mid-term and longer term, also need to be targeted with communications that help their acquisition of new knowledge following re-branding.
- 5 More attention should be given to administrative and clerical staff to ensure their more positive attitudes following re-branding do not fade.
- 6 As support for re-branding appears vital to a positively motivated workforce, every effort should be made towards getting staff behind the re-branding process from the start.
- 7 Greater behavioural change following re-branding needs to be encouraged particularly among middle/lower management and administrative/clerical levels. Linking behaviour to the more positive attitudes that result from the joint effects of time since re-branding with seniority, tenure and support, may translate into better behaviour over the longer term.

Future research

To develop an international perspective of the effects of time since re-branding on staff, this study should be replicated in the USA, Asia and other European countries.

To determine whether an optimum period exists of the beneficial effects of re-branding on staff, the study should be replicated on a sample of charities that re-branded less than two years ago and compare the results with those in this study.

A similar study should be undertaken in the for-profit sector and results compared with this study.

Finally, work should be undertaken to develop a typology of re-branding that reflects its continuous nature. Some re-branding exercises, such as changes to the logo or colours, are relatively trivial and may not be expected to require the same level of change that a fundamental re-alignment of vision requires. It might be expected, for instance that staff knowledge, attitudes and behaviours would not change where re-branding is on a superficial level.

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Appendix 1. Questions making up the "knowledge" composite variable

Knowledge

- Re-branding has increased my knowledge of what the charity does in terms of its (new) positioning, mission or purpose.
- Re-branding has made me more aware of the values the charity represents.
- Re-branding has increased my knowledge of whom the charity exists to serve.
- Since re-branding, I know our charity slogan (strapline).
- Re-branding has made me more aware of the key messages/themes our charity addresses (re-scaled item to positive statement).
- Overall, re-branding has made me feel better informed about the charity generally

1 = Strongly disagree 6 = Strongly agree

Appendix 2. Questions making up the “attitudes” composite variable

Attitudes

- Re-branding makes me think more about the charity's (new) positioning, mission or purpose.
- Re-branding makes me feel I'm doing a more worthwhile job.
- Re-branding has reminded me why I came to work here in the first place.
- Re-branding has made me feel more motivated in my job (re-scaled item to positive statement).
- Re-branding does make me feel more involved with the work of the charity (re-scaled item to positive statement).
- Re-branding makes me feel part of a team.
- Re-branding makes me feel more valued within the charity.
- Re-branding makes me feel responsible for how others see the charity.
- Re-branding has helped create a “nicer” place to work.
- I do feel I have played a part in the re-branding process (re-scaled item to positive statement).
- Overall, re-branding has had a positive effect on the way I feel about working here

1 = Strongly disagree 6 = Strongly agree

Appendix 3. Questions making up the “behaviour” composite variable

Behaviour

- Re-branding has made me more aware of carrying out my work duties in line with the charity's values (re-scaled item to positive statement).
- Re-branding has encouraged me to give feedback and make suggestions on how to improve the charity's performance.
- Re-branding has had an effect on how hard I work for the charity (re-scaled item to positive statement).
- Since re-branding, I have participated more in brand training activities such as seminars and workshops.
- Re-branding has encouraged me to behave more co-operatively towards my colleagues.
- As a result of re-branding, I am more likely to continue working here (re-scaled item to positive statement).
- As a result of re-branding, I am better trained and able to carry out my job more effectively.
- Overall, re-branding has had a positive effect on the way I behave towards my work colleagues.

1 = Strongly disagree 6 = Strongly agree

Appendix 4. Questions making up the “support” composite variable

Support

- I support the recent re-branding of my charity.
- It is important that staff support the re-branding of the charity for it to benefit from its effects.
- Staff support is a vital part of successful re-branding.

- It is important that other charity stakeholders such as volunteers buy into charity re-branding.
- Overall, re-branding has made me more supportive of the charity.

1 = Strongly disagree 6 = Strongly agree

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Executive summary

This executive summary has been provided to allow managers and executives a rapid appreciation of the content of this article. Those with a particular interest in the topic covered may then read the article in toto to take advantage of the more comprehensive description of the research undertaken and its results to get the full benefit of the material present.

People the key when re-branding a charity

Targeted, ongoing effort required to be successful

Time is a great healer, and also a great helper, at least when it comes to the re-branding of an organization. It takes people time to adjust. It takes them time to forget. It takes them time to remember. It takes time to get with the program. It takes time to conform.

A re-branding requires patience and care to be effective. In a world of immediate gratification, it harks back to past values when the pace was slower. Maybe there is something about being a human being that responds badly to the mechanistic pace of organizations, and has a slower more natural rhythm.

Its effectiveness needs to be measured, and three helpful dimensions to consider are:

- The acquisition of knowledge – at least remembering new strap lines, messages and values.
- More favourable attitudes from staff who are feeling involved, or valued by their organization.
- The demonstration of more positive behaviours by staff, manifested by their working more constructively with colleagues.

In a thoughtful study Philippa Hankinson of Roehampton University in London and Wendy Lomax and Chris Hand of Kingston University have conducted quantitative research examining the issue of time in nine leading UK charities. Their work involved a literature review of the for-profit as well as the not-for-profit sector, and secondly the exploration of the effects of time on staff knowledge, attributes and behaviours. In doing so, a particular focus was on the interaction of time with seniority, tenure and level of support for the re-branding process.

Impacts on knowledge, attitudes and behaviours

The results are interesting – sometimes intuitively sensible, at other times surprising.

Gaining staff buy-in to a re-branding effort is not something that diminishes over time. This, perhaps, is one of the most useful outcomes of this study. The level of support of the staff does have an impact, but this is not time sensitive. Efforts put into gaining staff support have lasting value. Something worth remembering in a world where so much is transitory.

When it comes to staff attitudes, however, time does matter. The closer people are in time to an enthusiastic re-branding effort the more positive they feel about it. With distance, the feeling dissipates somewhat. Seniority matters too. With seniority comes greater involvement in the decision-making. With greater involvement comes greater ownership of the issues. Senior people have a consistently more positive attitude than junior staff. Maybe the junior staff are just a bit tired of having yet another thing done to them.

With behaviour, behavioural change is most noticeable near the time of re-branding. It is a stimulating time, exciting even. Seniority matters however, with senior staff being more affected by the change. Surprisingly the level of support and length of tenure do not have a major impact on behavioural change patterns, and behavioural change is ultimately what the exercise is about.

Moving the agenda forward

So far so interesting, so what next? In this case it is refreshing to find research that can be readily crystallised into transferable principles, a blueprint for action.

If charged with a re-branding exercise, whether in a charity or elsewhere, seven golden rules emerge that increase the chances of being successful.

- 1 Re-branding is not a one-off event. Find ways of sustaining it.
- 2 If employing an outside agency a senior member of staff still needs to lead the efforts from the inside. Do not outsource your responsibilities.
- 3 Involve people such as administrative and clerical staff and communicate with them.
- 4 Help your longer serving staff to adjust. Tailor your communications to their needs.
- 5 Pay attention and make sure that positive attitudes among clerical and administrative staff do not fade.
- 6 Get staff behind the re-branding process from the start and you will have a much better chance of keeping them motivated.
- 7 Focus on getting greater behavioural change, particularly in the middle levels where people may feel they can hide.

Some of the rules may need slight amendment for different types of organizations, but clearer guidance is harder to imagine. The question for others is – will you follow them? Reading them is the easy part. Having the will to implement is a greater challenge.

Rather like the rhythms of time, as people we seem to find the need to go our own way and endlessly repeat the mistakes of the past, or fail to build upon the hard won knowledge, often expensively gained through expensive trails and tribulations elsewhere.

Progression is about building on firm foundations. It is about taking what is known and running with it, having paid due regard to its usefulness given unique circumstances. The simplicity of these lessons should not detract from their usefulness. To be profoundly beneficial research need not be opaque.

(A précis of the article “The time factor in re-branding organizations: its effects on staff knowledge, attitudes and behaviour in UK charities”. Supplied by Marketing Consultants for Emerald.)

This article has been cited by:

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